



THE GIRL GAMES

HOW SCHOOL LIBRARIES CAN PROVIDE
GENDER EQUITY IN E-GAMING

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Gaming has come to the library. School librarians are increasingly incorporating gaming into their program of resources and services. Besides addressing the natural interest that youth have in games, school librarians recognize the educational benefits of games, particularly in terms of information and digital literacies. While board games have been around for centuries, e-gaming (that is, playing video, console, and computer games) is a relatively new phenomenon. And, unlike board games that have interested both sexes, e-games seem to engage boys more than girls. How can school librarians address this apparent inequity and provide positive e-gaming experiences for all students?

The Youthful World of E-Gaming

E-games have come a long way from the early days of Pong. In 2010 the U.S. video game industry, encompassing almost nine thousand companies, posted \$40.7 billion in revenues and \$2.3 billion in profits. Two-thirds of the market segment consisted of games and software; another quarter consisted of consoles and accessories, and online subscriptions accounted for the rest (Thormahlen 2011). Two-thirds of U.S. homes own either a console or PC used to run e-games, and almost half of household heads play e-games on cell phones or PDAs (Entertainment Software Association 2011).

Even a decade ago, nearly all children played e-games or knew someone who did. By 2008, 97 percent of teens played video games, with three-quarters playing weekly, and a third playing daily; most played socially, with only a quarter usually playing alone (Kahne, Middaugh, and Evans 2008).

Gender Differences in E-Gaming

The face of e-gamers has changed recently. It is no longer a male domain; females now comprise forty percent of the e-gaming population, largely due to Nintendo's Wii and cell-phone casual e-games (Thormahlen 2011). Nevertheless, male youth tend to play e-games more frequently and for a longer time than do girls; the difference being most glaring between younger boys and older girls—the latter accounting for only 4 percent of the total video-game audience (Nielsen 2007).

More importantly, gaming practices differ along gender lines during teenage years. As girls enter puberty, their e-gaming activity drops significantly, largely because of continuing gendered perceptions about e-gaming. As teens explore their sexual identity, they are more sensitive to sexual stereotypes, and girls tend to distance themselves from the mechanical and violent nature of some e-games (Agosto 2004). Girls also have difficulty identifying themselves with the

characters, which tend to be male or non-human; moreover, the default female characters represent stereotypical sexualized images (Graner Ray 2004). In addition, girls are more likely to give up on a complicated game than are boys, and if girls have negative first experiences, they are less likely to become long-term gamers (Forssell 2008). Even seasoned girl gamers do not fit a simple boy-girl dichotomy because they tend to particularize their gaming behavior. Nonetheless, gendered differences fade with experience and age (Beavis and Charles 2007). These gendered differences can impact girls' futures. For instance, girls may generalize their negative e-gaming experiences, and avoid technology courses in college or as part of professional development.

As more courses incorporate e-gaming activities, girls may find themselves disadvantaged in such learning environments. Furthermore, since 85 percent of jobs now involve technology, girls who shy away from technology because of e-gaming failure may self-limit their professional options. Their avoidance of technology results in lost contributions to society.

Why E-Games?

E-gaming can be so engaging that it can detract from academics, but it can also foster 21st-century skills of information literacy, problem solving, communication, and collaboration. In terms of learning theory, e-gaming is usually associated with activity theory, which relates a subject and an object with mediational means; tools also mediate between the player and the larger culture. The characteristics of activity-theory-based gaming inform teaching and learning in several ways, according to Brian Myers: use of fixed, equitable structure and

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rules; clear goals within a rich context that provide meaning and relevance; opportunities to explore identities; cognitive and affective engagement; specific and timely feedback; and sense of control and personal investment (2008). These elements all resonate with girls, so the key to success for learning through e-games is gender-sensitive implementation.

E-games per se will not guarantee effective learning. Like other learning activities, they need to address academic content and concepts, and build skills and knowledge as players evaluate circumstances and solve problems successfully within the time frame available. Additionally, intentional instructional design to incorporate e-gaming is required; merely assigning an e-game without context and rationale will turn off girls in particular. On the other hand, when incorporated thoughtfully, e-games can introduce technology through motivating activities, improve problem-solving and collaboration skills, enhance spatial skills, and increase self-efficacy, all of which especially benefit girls (Brosnan 1998, Cooper and Weaver 2003). In short, when e-games are introduced in gender-inclusive ways, all students can succeed academically and psychologically.

E-Games in School Libraries

As school library programs support the academic and personal needs of students, these programs are trying to reach out to their population more proactively, meeting them on youth's territory. In terms of e-gaming, that can include gaming books, physical access and online links to educationally appropriate e-games, and incorporation of e-gaming in instruction. In the process, school librarians should consider the interests of girls in their game selection so that both sexes can enjoy e-gaming experiences.



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